

the worshipper of the Assyrio-Babylonian gods. . . . This—it may at least be supposed—was done in order to please his new subjects, and to gain the favour of the powerful sacerdotal body.

That Meyer's *ipse dixit* in itself would be accepted more readily than almost anyone's is undeniable, and in questioning it here I am rather denying than yielding to a "prejudice." We have nothing whatever from Cyrus's own hand which could possibly bear on the question, except the "Cylinder Inscription" with its profession of loyalty to Marduk, and the rescript in Ezra (1^{2,3}) where he declares that Yahweh is God. I do not draw the conclusion that Cyrus was a polytheist, for Darius, the fervent worshipper of Mazdah, makes the like concessions to his foreign subjects; but they will hardly be claimed as evidence that he really adored only the deity who is *not* mentioned! Of course, in the absence of Old Persian inscriptions from him,¹ the silence about Mazdah is intelligible enough. But it will not do for us to compensate for the silence by a mere "doubtless," which is all too often the cloak for a total absence of evidence. We have in fact only two sources of information to eke out Meyer's not very conclusive argument about the improbability that Darius was an innovator. We turn naturally to the Cylinder for what it may give us, which certainly is very little indeed.² The one conspicuous point we

¹ The Murghab inscription ("I am Cyrus the King, the Achæmenian") will not help us—even if it were quite certain that it does not belong to Cyrus the Younger, who might be *kyrabya* in the same sense as Darius's ancestors had the title.

² C. J. Ball, *Light from the East*, p. 224 f., translates the inscription. A microscopic criticism might note that Cyrus is